Final Assignment
Essay: Prompt 1

Vasconcelos

José Vasconcelos was a Mexican philosopher whose work stemmed from his experience of the Mexican Revolution, questioning how he could help guide Mexico forward. Being Mexico's first secretary of education, he gave lectures, expanded public education and brought about policies making access to important texts more affordable, and recruited artists and intellectuals for the Mexican Muralist Movement. In this essay, I will examine Vasconcelos' aesthetic utopianism in regards to the social binding problem by explaining the problem, Vasconcelos' understanding of history and races, and the benefits and shortcomings of a global community led by aesthetic utopianism.

Vasconcelos attempts to resolve the Social Binding Problem, "the problem of getting a group of people to share a framework of normative commitments for which they are prepared to at least sometimes sacrifice individual self-interest," to unite people through their social norms and foster benefits of long-term cooperation, thus finding his answer in 'aesthetic utopianism'.

Vasconcelo held the belief that history consists of three stages. The first stage was the "material" stage where human relations were driven by power and threats such that people gave up their self interests out of fear of those in power who were working towards larger goals. The second, or "political", stage was one where contracts, treaties, and laws are introduced, involving mutual self interest. This stage marks the development of social, moral, and political norms as we currently experience. Finally, Vasconcelos calls the final and third stage the "aesthetic" stage. In this stage, Vasconcelos proposes that humans are motivated by aesthetic concerns like love, beauty, and joy. This stage is supposed to be ushered in by the fifth cosmic race according to Vasconcelos. Vasconcelos had organised humans into four races, stating that each had a period where they flourished starting with the black race (Lumarians), then the red race (Atlanteans), then the yellow race, then the white race (Anglo-Saxons and Spaniards), and finally the cosmic race - a new race brought about by the mixing of all the races. In his opinion, these races don't follow a permanent hierarchy and they have distinct dispositions.

The three different ways of addressing the Social Binding Problem, as outlined by Vasconcelos, are nationalism and patriotism, international federations, and economic equality and social justice. Patriotism refers to loyal feelings and attachment towards a nation's common land and the shared legacy of its past through a framework accepted amongst people who share this passion. While this fosters a strong sense of unity through identity and bonds to the shared nation, it could lead to an array of issues such as xenophobia, othering and the exclusion of people they don't identify with in the same manner, and conflicts with other nations due to the larger scale social binding problem by prioritising national interests over global cooperation. International federations propose the formation of federations of various nations based on their political agreements, economic goals, or common cultural aspects like languages. However, the shortcomings here lie in aligning policies and handling conflicts of interest amongst participating parties due to the diversity in cultural aspects that have evolved over time and moulded to fit people practising the culture which might still pose barriers to complete integration. Lastly, economic equality and social justice focus on tackling inequalities in goods and confirming fair distribution of

resources to keep conflicts rooted in economic imbalances to a minimum. However, the challenge with this way of addressing the social binding problem is that it does not improve underlying cultural, racial, or ideological divides.

Aesthetic Utopianism is the idealistic concept suggested by Vasconcelos where individuals and nations are governed by aesthetic principles and spiritual oneness. This entails human relationships forged by sympathy for one another and mutual appreciation of beauty, thus sourcing joy rather than conflict from national differences. This addresses the social binding problem by including all races in a mega race called the cosmic race. This minimises exclusion of groups and celebrates the dissimilarities of various cultures through the creation of an overarching culture. This also demolishes the need for multiple laws, contracts, etc. holding people liable and instead provides the better incentive of one's own will which is more likely to be followed wholly.

While I am persuaded by Vasconcelos' Aesthetic utopianism, I do not completely agree with it as I believe that it does not pay heed to some practical aspects of human nature. I appreciate the mindset of regarding aesthetic values as I believe it leads to more whole-hearted and less performative human interactions. I think this change could make actions towards common goals blossom out of passion as compared to following the bare minimum as suggested by a set of rules enforced onto communities. However, this does not factor in human inconsistency and subjectivity. Human beliefs are ever changing and people's decisions are often swayed by convenience. If aesthetic utopianism was completely adopted by our world today, large scale decisions impacting multiple individuals may not always have effective results as they may not be aesthetic questions but questions that require reasoning to achieve long term goals. The other potential challenge, subjectivity, comes about as everyone has a different understanding and experiences different feelings of love, beauty, and joy due to their different roots that come along with different cultural values and practices of the same. Thus, the aesthetic utopianism might invalidate the uniqueness of individual aesthetic values.

Regardless of whether such aesthetic utopianism is possible in practice, in my opinion, offering such an idea of such a radical change in societal morals towards beauty, love, and joy to progress in terms of the social binding problem is a beneficial step towards attaining a more practical solution. In theory, if aesthetic utopianism did not propose such a radical change, it would not leave as deep of an imprint on its audience and thus it would be less impactful in bringing the world closer to spiritual unity.

In conclusion, Vasconcelos argued that shared values of love, beauty, and joy could transcend power, politics, and economics, providing a solution he deemed fit to foster unity. This was because he believed that history progresses through three stages: material, political, and aesthetic, culminating in a cosmic race uniting all humanity. Although his concepts push us to consider how artistic principles might solve social problems and advance spiritual harmony, his perspective might ignore the subjectivity and inconsistencies of people.